



FILM + TV PRIVATE CREDIT INSIGHTS

"Media Production Lending and Private Credit"

2023

V2 • 2026 Revised Edition • September 2026

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Introduction

Welcome to the latest Film + TV Private Credit Insights Report, brought to you by the research team at FilmHedge!

[FilmHedge](#) offers financing opportunities, credit data, risk ratings, and other financial data solutions for investors interested in film and TV financing as an asset class.

Overview

In a low-growth, illiquid market, growth and liquidity are priceless.

This report makes the case for **Media Credit** and **Media Production Lending (MPL)**, a type of specialty finance, as a serious consideration alongside venture capital, real estate, public markets, and private equity.

The concurrent Hollywood strikes in 2023 disrupted production and exposed the value of independent sources of capital. For eligible projects with a viable path to completion, private credit offered a way to finance production outside the traditional studio funding model.

SAG-AFTRA's interim agreements allowed rigorously vetted independent productions to work under specified union terms. They were agreements, not blanket waivers. Independent financing could support eligible productions, but it did not exempt a project from labor obligations or make every production financeable.¹²

With the strikes ending, the case for specialist production credit is clear. Producers have alternatives to studio financing, and lenders can underwrite contracted receivables rather than depend on a hit at the box office. The opportunity is to finance a defined transaction with a defined repayment source—and give producers more flexibility over how they bring their work to market.

Investors can use this report to assess where MPL belongs in a diversified portfolio. The strongest case rests on credit structure, potential yield, and shorter cash cycles. The benchmarks provide context; the loan documents determine the investment.

Notes and Disclosures

This report is an updated modestly revised and updated version of a report originally published around November 2023.

Numbered citations identify the sources listed near the end of the report and in the Errata and Methodology Addendum. This revised edition preserves our original's late-2023 perspective; the addendum explains substantive corrections and added historical context.

MPL figures are retained on the original report's stated unlevered basis. External benchmarks retain their source conventions, including fund fees and any leverage. Investment-level pricing, fund IRR, and public-market returns are distinct measures.

The MPL observations come from FilmHedge and its lending partners. VC, private equity, real estate, and private-debt benchmarks draw on broader samples. The MPL figures are company-reported observations, not an index.

FilmHedge's access to production budgets and financing structures provides a useful window into a specialized market.

Our original report states that we analyzed more than 300 productions annually against an estimated 2,500–3,000 annual releases. At 300, the arithmetic is 10–12%. Meaning how much of the market we 'touch', comparatively. Because reviewed projects and released titles are different populations, this is a scale comparison rather than measured market coverage.

The production-level information reviewed can include anonymized budgets, deal sizes, debt-to-equity financing ratios, state and international tax incentives, and interest rates. These inputs support underwriting; they are not substitutes for realized loan cash flows.

Cambridge private-fund returns are net fund-level IRRs; its public comparators use modified public market equivalents (mPME). PitchBook's VC observation is a rolling one-year IRR. The real estate observation was from 2021.

We retain the original comparisons, correct their labels, and distinguish reported MPL figures from independently sourced benchmarks. No new MPL return series, volatility estimate, or correlation calculation has been invented.

This is an investment thesis supported by historical context and transaction structure. It restates our position that MPL outperforms all other strategies on a common-period, net-of-fees, risk-adjusted basis. The addendum provides the calculation trails.

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Private Credit



Private credit, or private debt, expanded sharply over the decade preceding this report. SS&C's retained summary of Preqin data cites average annual growth of 13.5%, \$193.4 billion raised in 2021, and \$1.21 trillion in global assets under management at year-end 2021. Fundraising and AUM are different measures.^{1, 14}

Preqin's forecast cited in that source projected private-credit AUM of \$2.69 trillion by 2026 and anticipated that it could overtake real estate.^{1, 14} Private debt was already a substantial part of private markets. The Böni-Manigart study, published in 2022 using Preqin data, placed it at about 12.3% of private-capital fund assets. That scale gives specialist credit a meaningful institutional context.⁹

Private credit encompasses financing strategies that can offer higher yields than traditional fixed income. Managers serve borrowers and transactions that do not fit conventional bank lending, earning compensation for credit risk, illiquidity, complexity, and specialist execution.

Private Credit Definitions

The following definitions may be helpful to those unfamiliar with each strategy:

Senior Debt/Direct Lending - Many managers build relationships with private-equity sponsors and earn cash coupons comprising a fixed credit spread plus a floating reference rate. The older source refers to LIBOR; by 2023, the US-dollar market was transitioning to SOFR. Seniority and collateral must be evaluated at the actual loan level.^{7, 15}

Senior debt funds can be levered or unlevered. The retained Cambridge introduction (September 2017) describes indicative gross returns of 6-10% unlevered and up to 15% with leverage. These are historical strategy illustrations, not a quote for every 2023 loan.⁷

Distressed Debt - Distressed corporate credit managers typically target middle- to large-capitalization companies and purchase deeply discounted debt securities, either in the market

or bilaterally. They then endeavor to generate returns through negotiation, using the leverage they are afforded as creditors.

Mezzanine - Mezzanine managers provide junior capital to finance buyouts or acquisitions, typically making subordinated loans to lower-middle-market and upper-middle-market borrowers. Returns come from cash coupons over 10%, prepayment penalties, PIK interest, purchased equity/warrants, and penny warrants. Document negotiation is constrained by senior lenders and pricing closely follows market trends.

Special Situations and Specialty Finance - Special situations can span event-driven and opportunistic credit. Specialty finance focuses on assets or industries that require specialized expertise. The categories can overlap, but they are not interchangeable.

Media Production Lending (MPL) - a type of Specialty Finance.

Venture Debt - Specialized lenders provide financing to venture-backed businesses, often alongside equity funding. Underwriting can depend on company assets, cash runway, sponsor support, and prospects for additional capital. Warrants may add equity upside and dilution.

Trade Finance - Lenders provide working capital against transactions, goods, or receivables, often over short durations. Security interests and controlled payment flows can strengthen recovery prospects. The quality of the buyer, contract, collateral, and enforcement rights determines the credit risk.

These various strategies span a risk/return spectrum from capital preservation to return maximization. Capital preservation focuses on predictable cash flows from debt-like instruments. Return maximization targets greater upside through distressed debt or equity-like exposures but where risk is still managed.

Private Debt Fund Performance by Strategy ⁹

Performance Measures	All Funds	Direct Lending	Distressed Debt	Mezzanine	Special Situations	Venture Debt
Internal Rate of Return (IRR)	448	110	137	128	57	16
Mean	9.19	8.78	8.37	9.04	12.62	8.22
Median	8.50	7.90	8.30	9.40	8.00	8.60
SD	14.80	11.00	14.20	14.40	23.10	5.10
Net Multiples (X)	436	107	136	125	53	15
Mean	1.30	1.17	1.37	1.34	1.30	1.32
Median	1.24	1.14	1.30	1.29	1.18	1.19
SD	0.35	0.16	0.42	0.33	0.41	0.29
Public Market Equivalent (PME) - IG	448	110	137	128	57	16
Mean	1.08	1.04	1.08	1.09	1.10	1.09
Median	1.05	1.04	1.04	1.07	1.05	1.08
SD	0.25	0.13	0.29	0.27	0.30	0.18
Public Market Equivalent (PME) - HY	448	110	137	128	57	16
Mean	1.06	1.05	1.05	1.07	1.10	1.04
Median	1.04	1.04	1.05	1.02	1.06	1.03
SD	0.24	0.24	0.12	0.28	0.25	0.29
Public Market Equivalent (PME) - S&P 500	448	110	137	128	57	16
Mean	1.06	0.99	1.09	1.07	1.08	1.10
Median	1.01	0.99	0.98	1.04	0.99	1.06
SD	0.30	0.12	0.39	0.28	0.34	0.15

Source: Böni, Pascal and Manigart, Sophie, PRIVATE DEBT FUND RETURNS, PERSISTENCE, AND MARKET CONDITIONS (June 28, 2022) Financial Analysts Journal, forthcoming, Available at SSRN: ssrn.com/abstract=3932484 or dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.393248.

Ranking Mean Net IRR by Strategy ⁹

Rank	Strategy	Mean net IRR (%)	IRR SD (pp)
1.	Special situations	12.62	23.10
2.	Mezzanine	9.04	14.40
3.	Direct lending	8.78	11.00
4.	Distressed debt	8.37	14.20
5.	Venture debt	8.22	5.10

The source compares five private-debt fund strategies across 448 funds with vintages from 1986 to 2018. Its “special situations” category is preserved here rather than relabeled as the whole of specialty finance. IRRs are net of fees; dispersion is measured across funds. ⁹

Special situations ranks first by mean net IRR in this sample: 12.62%, compared with 9.04% for mezzanine, 8.78% for direct lending, 8.37% for distressed debt, and 8.22% for venture debt. The ranking is descriptive, not a forecast.

The result supports a clear point: specialized credit can reward differentiated expertise. The 23.10-percentage-point standard deviation also shows wide dispersion in both directions.

What the Strategy Rankings Tell Us

Private Credit managers employ specialized expertise to source deals and manage portfolios. Investment processes diverge after funding a loan or purchase. Exits rely on assets reaching maturity or having predictable cash flow streams.

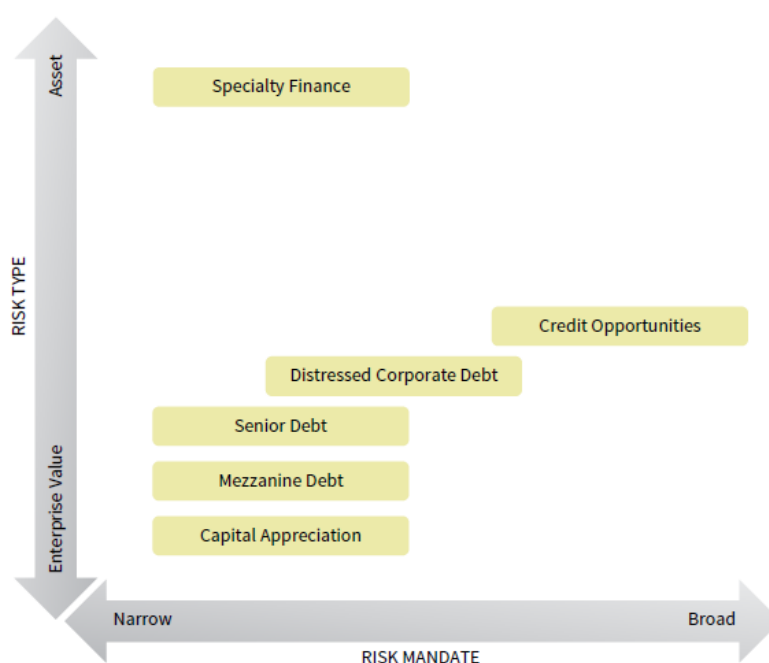
Strategies respond differently to the cycle. Distressed managers may find opportunities in dislocation; mezzanine and senior lenders depend heavily on borrower cash flows, leverage, and recovery rights.

For specialty strategies such as MPL, the decisive work is underwriting the underlying assets and the receivables pledged as collateral.

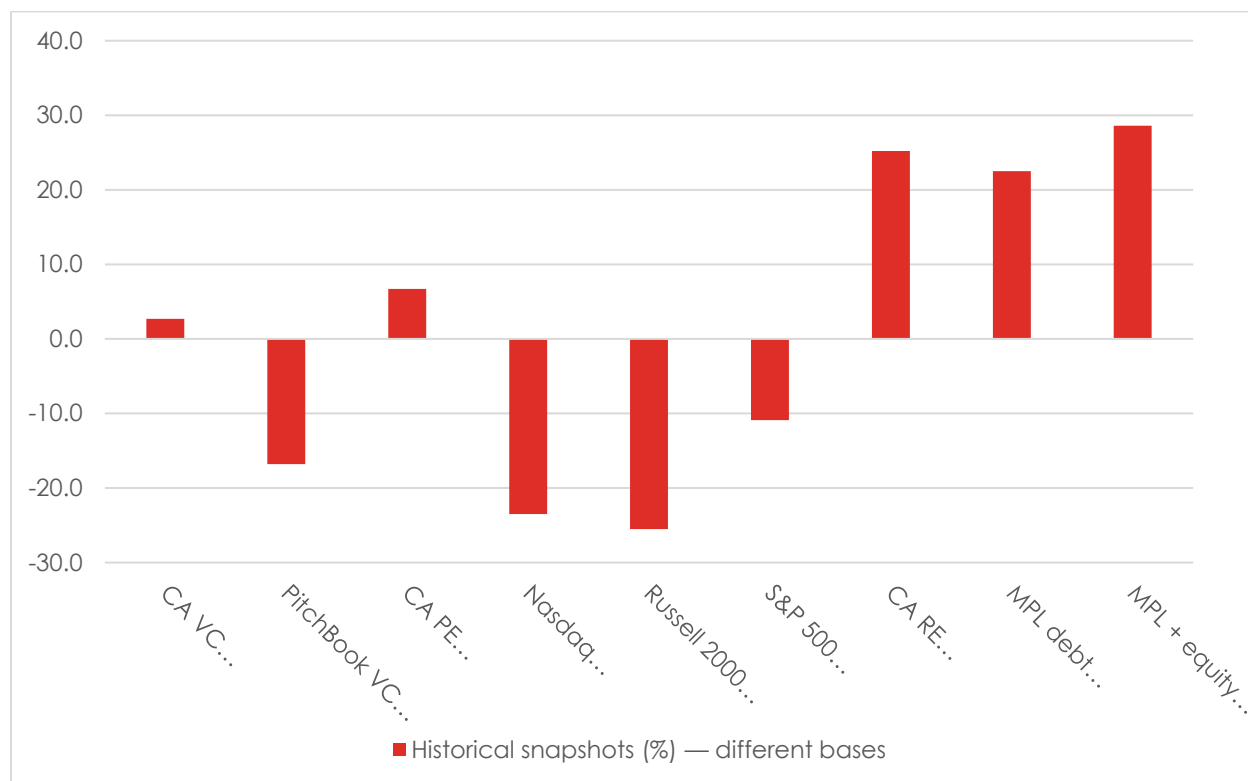
Risks include scale requiring extensive infrastructure, leverage potentially forcing asset sales, and legal jurisdiction impacting creditor rights.

Private credit offers a broad menu of yield and risk exposures. For investors, the task is to identify the source of repayment and the manager's edge, then align the structure with the portfolio's liquidity needs.

Illustrative Risk Mandate by Strategy (2017) ⁷



Historical Return Snapshots: Different Bases ^{3, 10, 11}



Basis: CA VC/PE and public mPME comparators—year to June 2022; PitchBook VC—year to March 2023; CA real estate—year to December 2021. MPL figures are originally reported benchmarks. See Notes and Errata.

Key Insights

Private credit is a broad category encompassing strategies that provide financing to companies not served by traditional lenders and banks.

The \$1.21 trillion figure measures year-end 2021 AUM. Assets, fundraising, and annual loan originations are distinct measures.¹⁴

Direct lending, distressed debt, mezzanine, special situations, and specialty finance have different sources of return and repayment.

Cambridge's historical framework spans single-digit gross return targets to more than 20%, reflecting different risks and structures.⁷

Contractual cash flows can diversify a portfolio's repayment drivers. Low statistical correlation must be demonstrated, not assumed.

Capital-preservation strategies emphasize cash flow and loss control. Historical mid-to-high-teen gross targets apply to mezzanine, not all senior debt.⁷

Distressed assets, capital appreciation, and equity participation can add upside and risk. Assess the source of each.⁷

Leverage is widely used by senior debt funds to enhance returns but brings risks of forced asset sales.

Jurisdiction and documentation influence recoveries. Review security, priority, enforceability, and the practical costs of a workout.

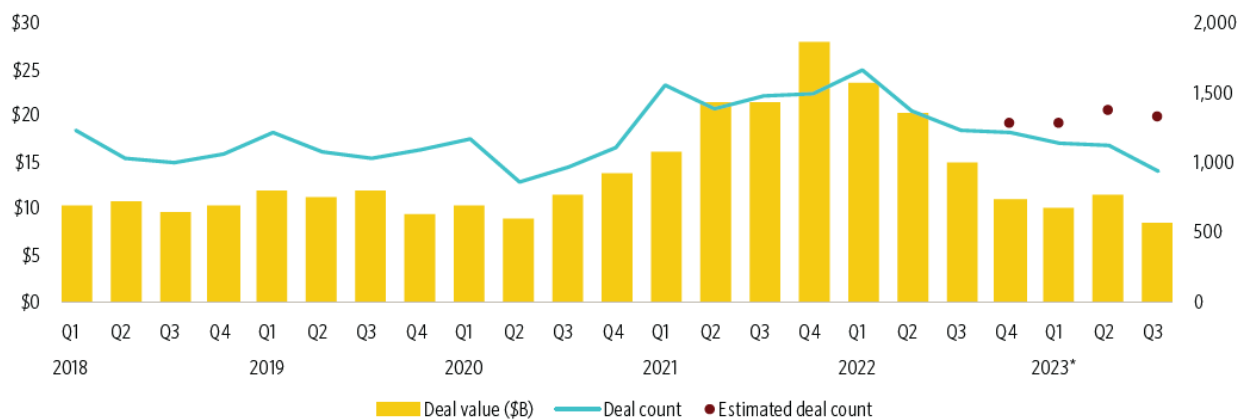
Venture Capital



By Q3 2023, US venture capital was well below its 2021 peak in both deal value and activity. The pressure was real, but the distinction between recorded deals, estimated deals, and investment performance matters.³

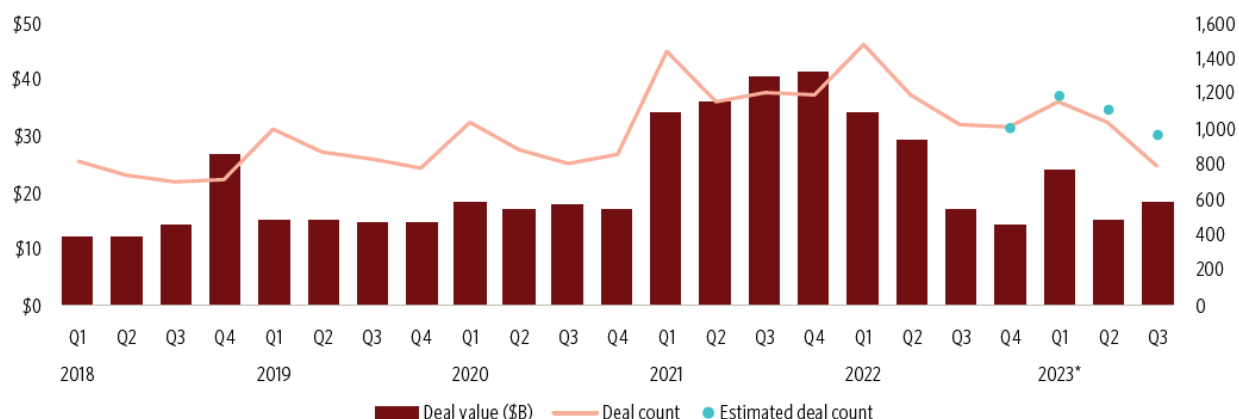
Early-stage activity had weakened, and megadeals of more than \$100 million accounted for 48.5% of Q3 deal value, down from 60.0% in Q4 2021. Software activity was subdued while life sciences had gained relative share since 2020.³

US early-stage VC deal activity by quarter



PitchBook-NVCA Venture Monitor
*As of September 30, 2023

US late-stage VC deal activity by quarter



PitchBook-NVCA Venture Monitor
*As of September 30, 2023

In 2022, almost half of capital raised went to funds of more than \$1 billion. Through Q3 2023, funds between \$100 million and \$1 billion attracted nearly two-thirds of capital raised. These figures describe fundraising concentration, not fund performance.³

Emerging managers faced a difficult fundraising market: 73.3% of capital raised through Q3 went to experienced firms, defined in the source as firms with at least four funds. First-time funds were on pace for their lowest annual count in a decade.³

Overall, the market was under strain. More companies needed bridge financing, insider rounds, or lower valuations to extend their runway, while investors became more selective about leading new rounds.³

"Overall, the venture capital market is still under great strain."

Investors and entrepreneurs were looking for security and cash flow, even as substantial capital remained available. The Inflation Reduction Act and CHIPS and Science Act provided longer-term support for relevant industries, and AI and life sciences continued to attract interest. The reset did not erase the opportunity for innovation; it made access to capital and the path to an exit more demanding.³

Key Insights

Venture capital's long-term record helps explain its place in institutional portfolios. The short-term reset should be viewed alongside that record:

- Cambridge's June 2022 comparison shows US venture capital ahead of its Nasdaq mPME comparator over the 5-, 10-, 15-, and 25-year horizons. The size of that advantage varies materially with the horizon.¹⁰
- Access, manager selection, vintage, and the rest of the portfolio matter.
- However, VC comes with higher risk, low liquidity, long time horizons, and more complexity than public markets. The outperformance is compensation for these factors.
- VC can be attractive for investors with the time horizon, risk appetite, and access to pursue its potential. MPL deserves consideration for a different role: shorter contractual cash cycles alongside long-duration growth exposure.

An Upset Market: U.S. Venture Capital Trends as of Q3 2023

US VC rolling one-year returns turned sharply negative as the 2021 valuation boom unwound. The retained PitchBook series shows that one-year IRR fell from 79.7% in Q2 2021 to –18.4% at year-end 2022 before improving to –16.8% in Q1 2023.³

“Venture capital’s 2023 reset made the timing of cash distributions a central concern.”

The Q3 2023 workbook reports rolling one-year VC IRR of –8.0% for Q3 2022 and –16.8% for Q1 2023. The latter is the “2023” observation used in our chart; it is not a full-year 2023 result. This was a severe reset, but the modest improvement from Q4 2022 means the series did not decline in every subsequent quarter.³

Fewer exits and valuation markdowns made capital harder to recycle. For LPs, the practical issue was not simply a negative headline return: it was the timing and amount of distributions available to meet new commitments. That makes the cash-flow profile of complementary strategies especially relevant.³

Key Insights

The retained PitchBook-NVCA workbook supports this US snapshot. Estimated counts include deals not yet reported; stage totals can differ slightly from aggregates.³

- Q3 2023 recorded \$36.7 billion across 2,716 deals, or 3,705 deals including estimates.³
- Nine-month 2023 deal value totaled \$125.9 billion, versus \$244.5 billion for full-year 2022 & \$347.3 billion for 2021.³
- Pre-seed & seed activity totaled \$3.2 billion across 1,214 recorded-plus-estimated deals in Q3.³
- Year-to-date median seed deal size was \$3.0 million, unchanged from 2022.³
- Early-stage deal value in Q3 was \$8.5 billion across 1,341 recorded-plus-estimated deals.³
- Median early-stage deal size was \$4.9 million through Q3, down 26.7% from 2021 using unrounded values.³
- Late-stage Q3 activity reached \$18.4 billion and 970 deals including estimates; venture growth added \$6.6 billion and 175.³
- Year-to-date median late-stage pre-money valuations were \$52.2 million, down 14.5% from 2022.³
- Q3 exit value rose to \$35.8 billion across 284 recorded-plus-estimated exits, with large public listings contributing to the rebound.³
- VC IPO and DeSPAC performance indexes remained down roughly 50% or more from January 2022—a performance measure, not exit value.³
- Through Q3, 344 US VC funds had raised \$42.7 billion. Fund count was on pace for a nine-year low.³

- Experienced firms attracted 73.3% of capital raised through Q3; first-time fundraising remained difficult. ³
- Median fund size was \$30.0 million; average size was \$132.1 million. ³

Angel Investing



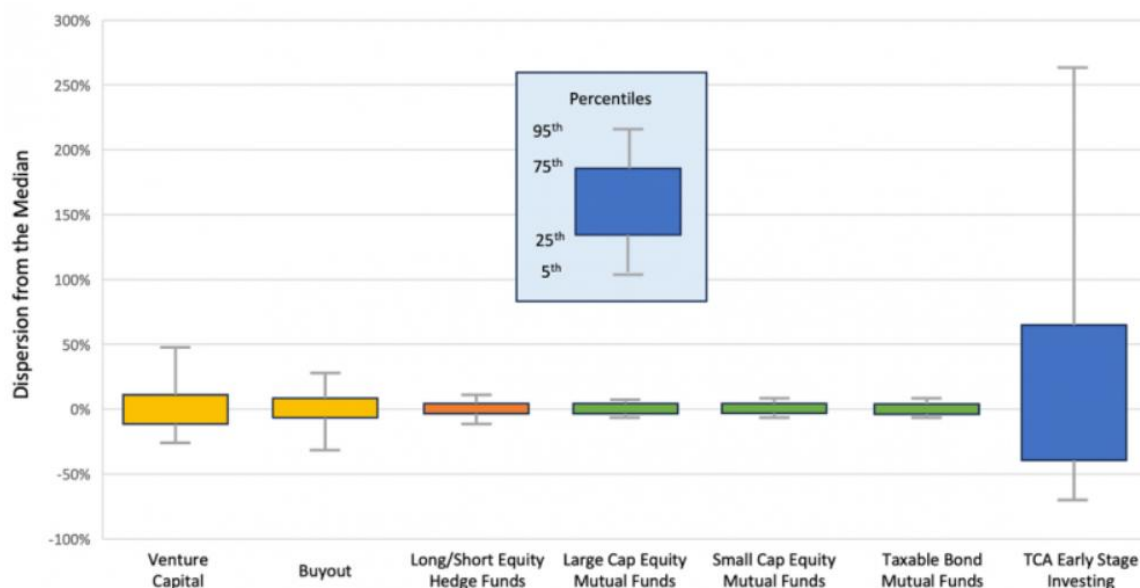
Closely related to venture capital is angel investing. Angels generally invest earlier in a company's life, taking substantial business risk before institutional venture funding. Follow-on capital and eventual exits are important drivers of portfolio value.

A 2023 Angel Capital Association (ACA) analysis offers a useful comparison, drawing on the realized outcomes of two angel groups.⁸

The two portfolios reported annualized IRRs of 31.0% and 25.2%. Those are strong results, but they describe these cohorts and their assumptions—not a return every angel investor can expect.⁸

A few “grand slam” investments account for most gains, much like venture capital. ACA's John Harbison emphasizes diversification and cites a 10-20% early-stage allocation as a rule of thumb. The appropriate allocation depends on the investor's circumstances.⁸

The comparison illustrates the upside available to successful angel portfolios. It also makes clear why patient capital, broad exposure, and tolerance for loss are central to the strategy.



Dispersion of Returns for Active Managers (Different Bases) ⁸

ACA compared two angel cohorts with public and venture benchmarks. The angel figures span their full histories, while the other columns use 5-, 10-, and 15-year windows. Their strong annualized results should not be confused with cumulative gains over those periods. ⁸

Index / cohort	5-year	10-year	15-year	Full-history IRR
DJIA	9.9%	11.8%	9.4%	—
Nasdaq	14.0%	15.8%	12.7%	—
S&P 500	11.8%	13.0%	9.8%	—
Russell 2000	6.9%	9.9%	7.7%	—
Emerging markets	0.9%	3.2%	1.4%	—
Bloomberg VC	21.1%	16.4%	10.3%	—
CTAN (17 years)	—	—	—	31.0%
TCA (25 years)	—	—	—	25.2%

CTAN is the Central Texas Angel Network; TCA is Tech Coast Angels. CTAN's 115 outcomes from 2006–2022 produced a reported IRR of 31.0%, and TCA's 247 outcomes from 1997–2022 produced 25.2%, assuming equal investment amounts per company. The angel figures are full-history annualized IRRs, not 15-year returns. ⁸

The simple arithmetic mean is 28.1%: $(31.0\% + 25.2\%) \div 2$. It is a summary of two reported IRRs, not the IRR of a combined portfolio.

Key Insights

- CTAN reported a 31.0% annualized IRR across its 2006–2022 outcomes.⁸
- TCA reported a 25.2% annualized IRR across its 1997–2022 outcomes.⁸
- The earlier angel studies cited by ACA reported IRRs of 22–27% for different cohorts. Their periods and methods should be kept distinct.⁸
- ACA also cites a historical CB Insights statistic that 66% of VC funds yielded less than 10%. The retained report does not identify that statistic's sample or cutoff, so it is context rather than a contemporaneous benchmark.⁸
- ACA's BlackRock comparison uses forward-looking return expectations, while the angel figures are historical outcomes. It illustrates different risk profiles rather than a matched-period performance ranking.⁸
- At TCA, eight of 247 outcomes—3.2%—produced 77% of dollars returned. Concentration in a handful of winners is a defining feature of these results.⁸
- ACA's simulation of 20,000 portfolios, each containing 25 investments drawn from TCA's first 159 outcomes, illustrates a wide range of possible returns. It is a simulation, not 20,000 observed portfolios.⁸
- The retained dispersion graphic combines different periods, measures, and a simulated angel distribution. It is useful context for concentration risk, not a uniform volatility ranking.⁸
- The portfolio lesson is diversification across repayment drivers and time horizons, as well as across individual companies.

Venture Debt



Venture debt provides debt capital to venture-backed startups and growth companies. It may rely on company assets, cash runway, contracted revenue, and expectations of continued equity support. Collateral and guarantees vary by transaction.

Venture debt often includes warrants that give lenders a right to purchase equity. It can limit dilution relative to an equity round, but warrant exercise can still dilute ownership. Priority over equity is valuable; it does not guarantee repayment.

Banks and specialist credit funds are important suppliers of venture debt. The structure can extend a company's runway between equity rounds and reduce the amount of equity it needs to sell.

Its usefulness depends on the borrower's capacity to repay or refinance. Debt can support growth, but it cannot replace a credible financing plan for a company that continues to consume cash.

That distinction became more important in 2023 as venture funding tightened. The original report's strongest evidence is the observed contraction in financing activity, rather than an untraceable forecast of future market size.

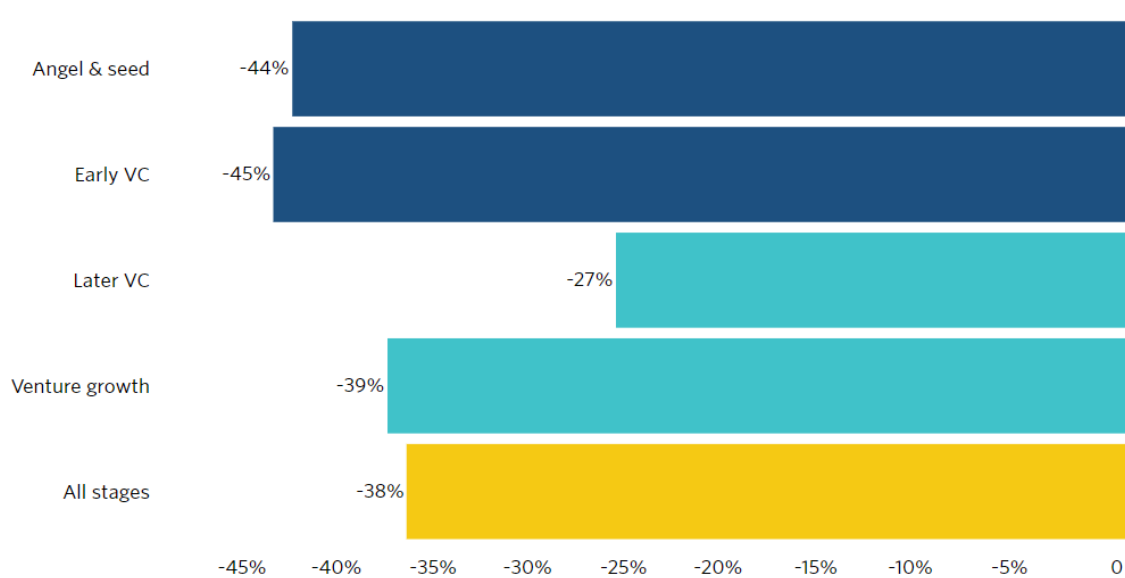
Early-stage venture debt activity weakened in the first half of 2023, a period that included Silicon Valley Bank's failure. Lenders and borrowers faced a more difficult funding environment; the activity data alone does not isolate how much of the decline was caused by that event.

The retained stage chart reports year-over-year first-half declines in deal count of 44% for angel/seed, 45% for early stage, 27% for late stage, and 39% for venture growth.

The evidence points to a sharp contraction in first-half 2023 lending activity.

Venture Debt Activity: First-Half 2023 Contraction

YoY change in venture debt deal count by stage in H1 2023



Source: Q2 2023 PitchBook-NVCA Venture Monitor

Geography: US

*As of June 30, 2023

Key Insights

- The report's retained totals show \$6.34 billion across 931 deals in the first half of 2023, versus \$20.07 billion across 1,513 deals a year earlier: declines of 68.4% in value and 38.5% in count.
- The retained stage chart shows the largest percentage declines in deal count at early stage (45%) and angel/seed (44%).
- Late-stage and venture-growth counts also declined.

Media Production Lending



Media Production Lending can turn a production's contracted receivables into investable credit exposure. This is also referred to as Media Credit.

MPL provides private credit against film and TV assets during production. In the senior, receivables-backed structure examined here, repayment is underwritten against fixed contractual obligations—such as distribution minimum guarantees—and eligible tax incentives. Buyers may include major studios and streamers or independent distributors; each obligor and contract requires its own credit assessment.

Reported MPL terms: 12–15 months, with 15–27.5% annualized pricing before leverage.

The closest analogy is trade finance: working capital advances against a transaction with an identifiable takeout. The original report describes typical MPL terms of 12–15 months and unlevered annualized pricing of 15–27.5%. These are reported commercial terms, not an independently recalculated net fund return or a demonstrated correlation statistic.

The distinction from equity investing is fundamental. A fixed distribution payment need not rise or fall with ticket sales once its contractual conditions are met. Equity and speculative gap financing remain exposed to audience economics. MPL still carries production, delivery, buyer-credit, collection, and enforcement risks.

Private Debt Mean Net IRR by Strategy ⁹

Rank	Strategy	Mean net IRR (%)	IRR SD (pp)
1.	Special situations	12.62	23.10
2.	Mezzanine	9.04	14.40
3.	Direct lending	8.78	11.00
4.	Distressed debt	8.37	14.20
5.	Venture debt	8.22	5.10

The original MPL debt benchmark of 22.5% sits above the study's 12.62% special-situations mean.

MPL Reported Benchmark and Special Situations

Strategy / observation	Return (%)	IRR SD (pp)
Special situations (net mean IRR)	12.62	23.10
MPL debt (reported benchmark)	22.50	Not verified

Basis: special situations is a 57-fund, net-of-fees sample; MPL is the original FilmHedge-reported benchmark. Its cash-flow and dispersion calculations could not be reproduced from the retained files. "Not verified" is not zero risk. See Errata.

The Gilded Age: How Hollywood Business Models Have Changed

What is driving the emergence of MPL as a form of financing for Film and TV productions?

The movie industry has gone through a tremendous transformation—streaming, artificial intelligence, and independent financing have changed the game. We are entering an era that, in important ways, turns Hollywood's old studio model inside out.

During Hollywood's studio era, major studios brought much of financing, production, talent, and distribution under one roof. They were both the banks and the bosses to producers and visionary filmmakers. Vertical integration shaped who could make a picture and how it reached an audience.

Today, independent productions can assemble those functions from different providers. Independent financiers are part of that disaggregation, opening transactions to capital outside the studio balance sheet. What does that mean?

When producing a Film or TV series independently, disaggregation means the financing and resources that the producer needs in order to get that film finished and released aren't provided by the same company.

A producer may work with one financier for tax credits, another for equity, and a lender such as FilmHedge or its partners for senior debt. A soundstage may contribute services, while separate firms provide payroll, insurance, casting, catering, and production support.

For investors, this creates distinct points of entry into film and television finance. The opportunity is to choose the risk being financed rather than treat every dollar invested in a production as the same bet.

Modern film financing models work because of groups who aren't focused on the whims of studio execs (or the whims of creators for that matter). Instead, they focus on the trade, the deals to be delivered and transactions to be completed. This solves a problem for both the buyer and the seller.

Mark Twain's phrase "the Gilded Age" is a useful lens for a period of economic change, tension, and fortunes made and lost. Hollywood is experiencing its own contest between established models and new sources of technology, distribution, and capital.

Financial structuring, generative content, data, artificial intelligence, and social media are redefining the business of content. The tension is real—and so is the opportunity for financiers who understand the transactions beneath the headlines.

What Media Production Lending Has in Common with Trade Finance

For receivables-backed production lending, modern film finance is a trade finance business.

Films are the inventory; producers are the suppliers; distributors are the buyers; and streaming platforms, theaters, and stores connect the work to consumers. Companies such as FilmHedge provide working capital against those commercial relationships, with assigned receipts used to repay the loan.

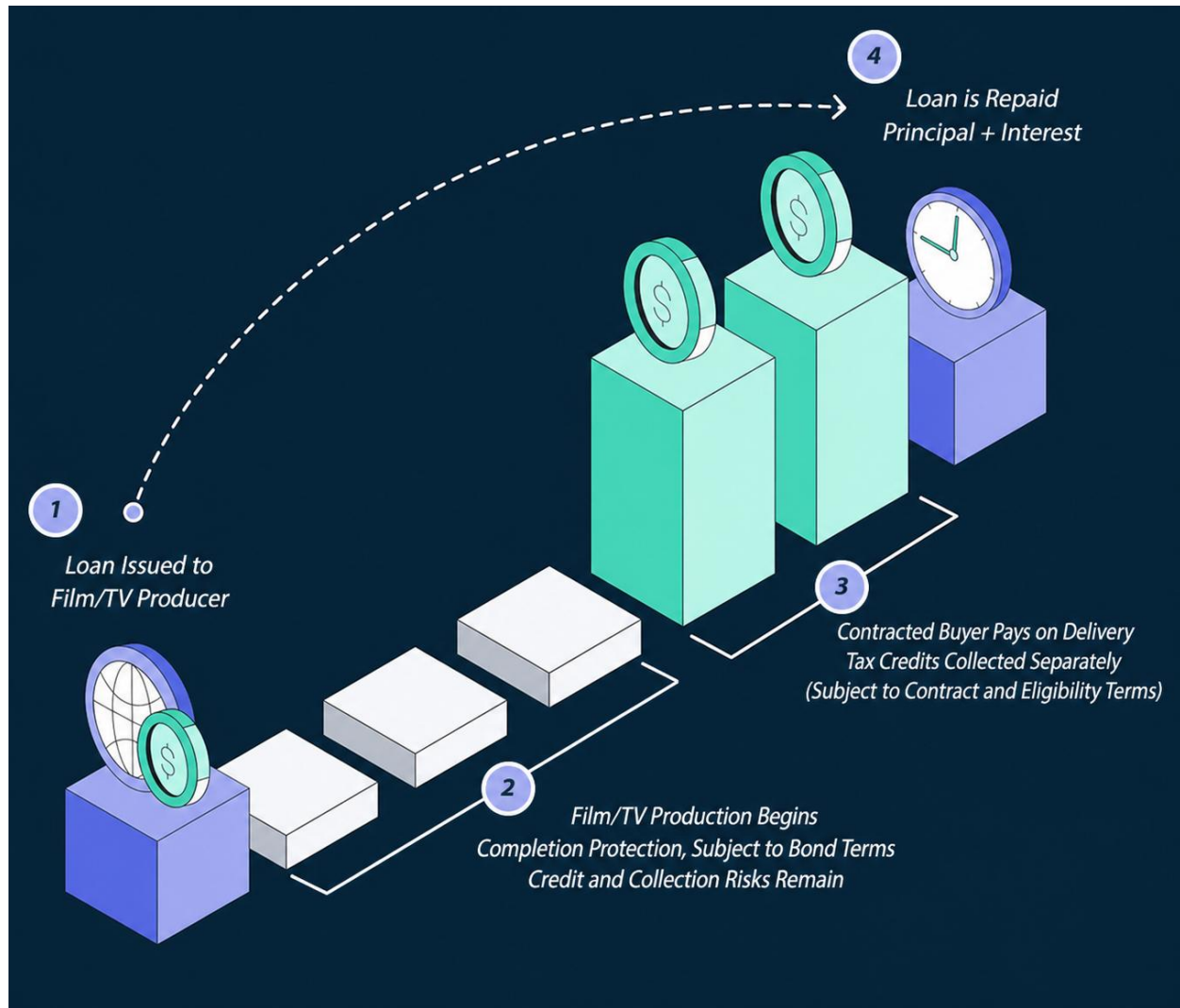
A production may combine licensing commitments from distributors with eligible tax incentives in jurisdictions such as Georgia or Canada. Georgia's incentive can reach 30% of qualifying expenditure when its conditions are met. Sales agents connect productions with buyers in different territories. These are identifiable transactions that a specialist lender can assess.

"Modern film finance is a trade finance business."

Receivables-backed film lending has a long history. What deserves fresh attention is its place in an investor's portfolio. Film equity depends on the success of the underlying rights; media credit can instead focus on an agreed payment, a delivery obligation, and a controlled collection process.

Under a negative-pickup or similar distribution agreement, a buyer commits to pay an agreed amount when specified delivery conditions are met. The lender can evaluate that contract before advancing funds. The commercial question shifts from predicting a hit to assessing whether the receivable will become payable and collectible.

Media Production Lending and Trade Finance



Media lenders bridge the gap between production spending and collection. Producers receive working capital; contracted buyers can pay at delivery rather than fund every production cost upfront. Tax-incentive receipts follow their own eligibility and payment processes. The lender manages these timing and credit risks through structure, documentation, and monitoring.

Picture vs. Venture: Benchmarking Media Production Lending & Venture Capital



In a low-growth, illiquid economy, growth and liquidity are priceless.

Our purpose is to put MPL on the institutional allocation map. Comparing its reported economics with VC, real estate, public markets, and private equity helps frame that discussion, provided each figure keeps its proper date and measurement basis.

“Media Production Lending offers a different cash cycle: contracted receivables and shorter loan terms.”

Venture capital has earned its place in institutional portfolios. Alumni Ventures’ research highlighted its long-term outperformance, citing Cambridge Associates. Our comparison starts from that strength: investors who value long-duration growth may also value credit with a more explicit path to repayment.

5, 10

MPL deserves a seat at the allocation table. It offers a distinct way to participate in the media economy: financing the production and delivery of contracted assets, with underwriting centered on the payer, the collateral, and the collection timetable.

For LPs with substantial exposure to venture, the attraction is a complementary cash-flow profile. MPL can offer shorter loan maturities and a contracted takeout. Whether that becomes liquidity for the LP depends on collections, reinvestment policies, and the fund’s distribution terms.

Historical Return Snapshots: Basis Matters ^{3, 10, 11}

Observation	Return (%)	Measurement basis
CA US VC	2.7	1 year to June 2022
PitchBook US VC	-16.8	1 year to March 2023
CA US private equity	6.7	1 year to June 2022
Nasdaq mPME	-23.5	VC cash flows; year to June 2022
Russell 2000 mPME	-25.5	VC cash flows; year to June 2022
S&P 500 mPME	-10.9	VC cash flows; year to June 2022
CA real estate	25.2	1 year to December 2021
MPL debt (reported)	22.5	Original benchmark; basis unverified
MPL debt + equity (reported)	28.6	Original benchmark; basis unverified

CA public-market figures are VC-cash-flow-matched mPME returns. MPL figures remain original reported benchmarks, not verified net fund IRRs. Different dates and methods preclude a universal performance ranking.

Media Production Lending

MPL is a specialty-finance strategy for short-term lending against film and TV productions with identifiable collateral and a documented repayment plan. Pre-negotiated distribution payments and eligible tax incentives can provide the takeout. Advance rates should leave room for costs, delays, and collection shortfalls.

A completion guarantee or bond can protect covered financiers against specified failure to complete and deliver a production. Depending on the agreement, the guarantor may fund completion, take over production, or reimburse covered advances. ¹⁶

Completion protection, budget oversight, security interests, and controlled receipts work together. Their value is practical: they address identifiable risks and support a defined lending term. Credit losses, disputes, delays, and exclusions still require underwriting.

In a contracted MPL transaction, the producer delivers the agreed production and the buyer's payment is applied through the agreed collection arrangements. The lender holds security over relevant receivables and rights. This borrower-buyer-lender relationship is why the trade-finance analogy is useful.

The measured benchmarks are 22.5% for MPL debt and 28.6% when mezzanine and equity participation are included. We retain them as reported observations, subject to the methodology limits described earlier. The second figure includes additional risk and is not a pure senior-debt return.

Venture Capital

Venture capital finances innovation and growth in young companies. In 2023, lower valuations and constrained exits challenged value realization. Its long-term appeal remained the possibility of exceptional gains from a small number of successful companies.

The challenges investors have with venture capital aren't just limited to the current moment. The biggest challenge for investors is that venture allocations are usually mostly illiquid across long time horizons (sometimes a decade or longer).

Investors like VC fund allocations because they offer a way to spread risk across multiple high-risk early-stage companies with the hopes that one or two will find explosive growth and exit at a valuation that is outsized.

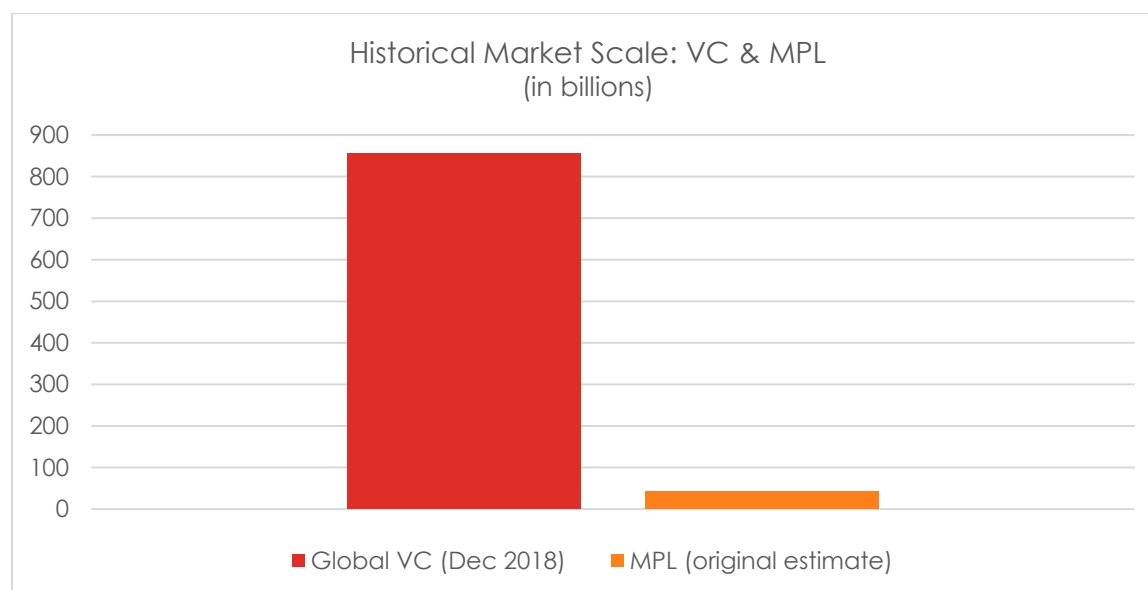
The retained evidence supports VC's long-term potential and its sensitivity to timing. The June 2022 Cambridge snapshot shows strong multi-year returns alongside a sharp six-month decline. Both observations belong in a fair comparison.¹⁰

Historical Market-Scale Comparison

The original chart used approximately \$850 billion for global VC AUM. Its cited Preqin release actually reports \$856 billion as of December 2018. We correct the transcription to \$856 billion and retain the historical date rather than present it as a 2023 market total.⁶

FilmHedge's original working estimate for media production lending is \$43 billion. It was derived from information about known lending firms, but the retained files do not provide a firm-by-firm reconciliation. It is an indicative estimate, not a peer-reviewed or verified industry total.

The MPL estimate was intended to cover production finance, including advances against eligible state and sovereign tax incentives, pre-sale contracts, and distribution agreements. It excludes studio construction, content-library lending, and general corporate borrowing by entertainment companies.



This chart preserves the original scale comparison, with its dates and scope made explicit. The \$856 billion VC figure is a historical global AUM measure; the \$43 billion MPL figure is a differently constructed working estimate. Their ratio is not a measure of penetration, market share, or investable capacity.

MPL is a specialized credit activity within broader media finance. Equity, mezzanine, corporate lending, and infrastructure finance have different underwriting questions and should be assessed separately.

For the central thesis, MPL means senior, collateralized lending to film and TV productions. The debt-plus-equity benchmark is shown separately because adding participation changes the risk profile.

Industry complexity can create a role for specialist expertise. It does not, on its own, prove that the market is undercapitalized or that larger allocations can be deployed at the same yield.

Interpreting the Return Comparison

A useful benchmark keeps three things visible: the return measure, the measurement period, and the capital bearing the risk. An investment-level pricing range cannot be treated as a net LP return without the intervening cash flows and costs.

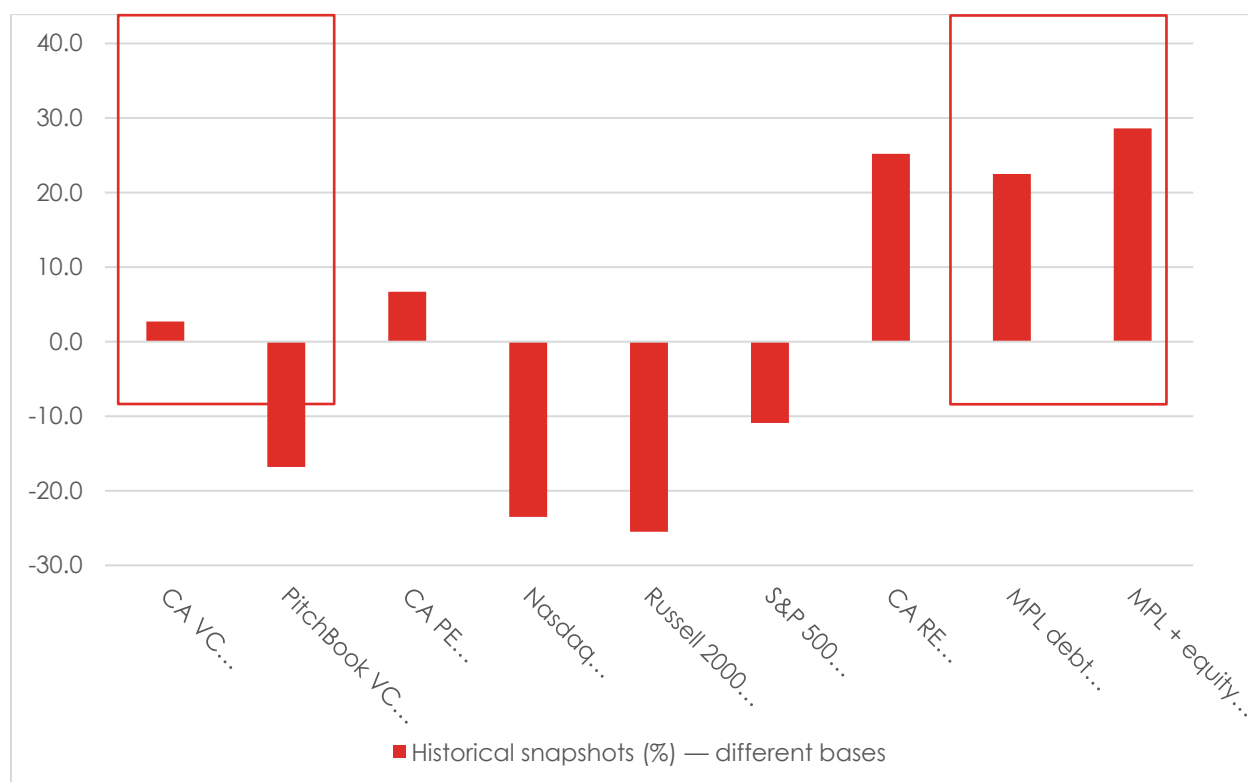
The original Cambridge observations of 2.7% for VC and 6.7% for private equity are one-year results to June 30, 2022. Its longer horizons show why a difficult short period does not erase the case for venture.

¹⁰

PitchBook's -16.8% VC figure is a rolling one-year IRR to March 31, 2023. A negative IRR reflects valuation and cash-flow outcomes; it does not by itself establish why deployment or fundraising slowed. GPs issue capital calls and LPs fund them. ³

The retained PitchBook series reports -18.4% for the year to December 2022. That differs from Cambridge's 2.7% year-to-June observation because both the date and the dataset differ. ^{3, 10}

Historical Return Snapshots: Different Bases 3, 10, 11



Periods: CA VC/PE and public mPME—year to June 2022; PitchBook VC—year to March 2023; CA real estate—year to December 2021. MPL values are originally reported, with no retained cash-flow reconciliation. See Errata for the full basis.

The original comparison highlights attractive reported MPL economics during a difficult period for venture. It should be read as a set of historical snapshots, not as a single-period league table.

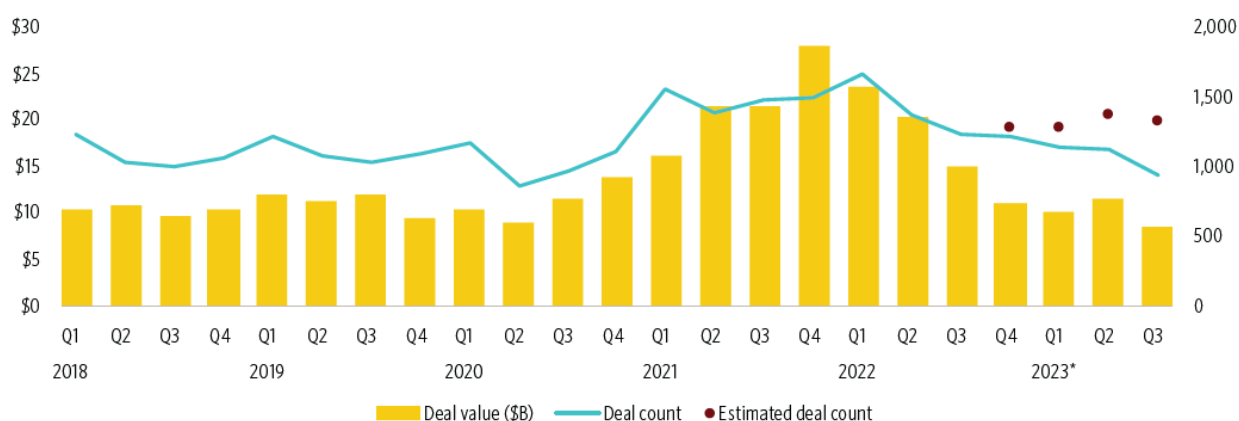
The conclusion is meaningful: investors can examine production credit for yield and shorter contractual repayment cycles. Adding mezzanine or equity may increase upside, but it also changes the risk and can extend the time to realization.

The retained early- and late-stage charts show a substantial reset from 2021 activity. They measure financing volume and deal count, not fund returns. The late-stage Q3 rebound in dollar volume is preserved in the original chart.³

2023 was a reset after the funding boom, not evidence of five uninterrupted years of decline. The duration of the adjustment remained uncertain at the time of writing.

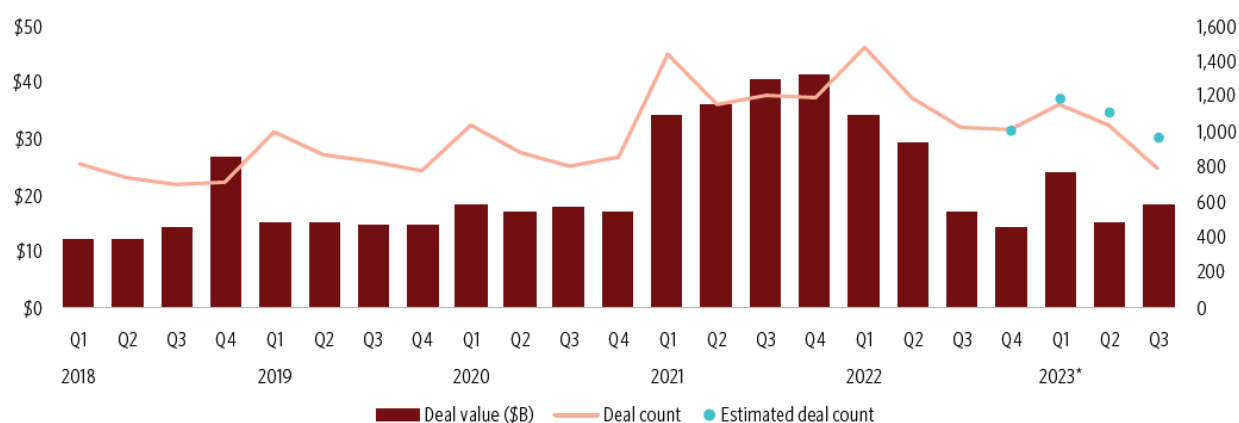
Venture debt also contracted in the first half of 2023. Its shared exposure to startup financing conditions is relevant to diversification, even though the activity figures do not establish lender losses.

US early-stage VC deal activity by quarter



PitchBook-NVCA Venture Monitor
*As of September 30, 2023

US late-stage VC deal activity by quarter



PitchBook-NVCA Venture Monitor
*As of September 30, 2023

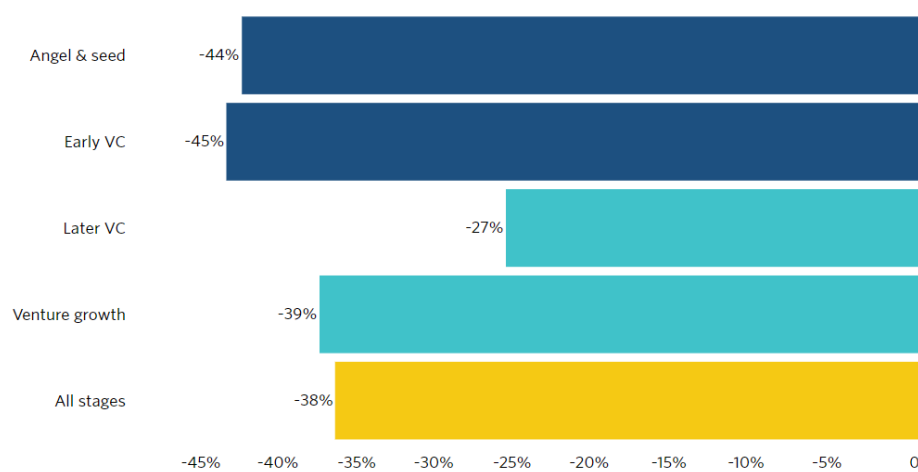
The Angel Investor Alternative

The angel comparison strengthens the case for a different cash cycle. CTAN and TCA reported annualized IRRs over 17- and 25-year outcome histories; their 28.1% simple mean is not a cumulative return over 15–20 years. The evidence therefore supports MPL’s potential duration advantage.

The original MPL terms—12–15 months and 15–27.5% unlevered annualized pricing—describe a different investment proposition from waiting for equity exits. That can be useful alongside an angel portfolio.

Venture Debt Activity: First-Half 2023

YoY change in venture debt deal count by stage in H1 2023



Source: Q2 2023 PitchBook-NVCA Venture Monitor

Geography: US

*As of June 30, 2023

Venture debt can complement equity by extending runway and financing growth. Its sharp first-half 2023 contraction shows that it is still exposed to the startup financing cycle. It does not demonstrate that the strategy has always been in decline.

For LPs seeking additional sources of repayment, the relevant question is how much of the portfolio depends on the next financing round or equity exit. Contracted production receivables offer a different underwriting focus.

VC managers and other allocators can evaluate specialist production credit on that basis, while recognizing the expertise needed to originate, document, and collect the loans.

“The case for MPL: specialist credit, contracted repayment, and shorter production cash cycles.”

The Case for MPL

MPL deserves serious consideration as a complement to long-duration private equity. It can finance a tangible production schedule against identifiable payment obligations, creating opportunities to return or redeploy capital as loans repay.

Our original report describes MPL vehicles with 2-5-year terms, compared with venture funds commonly requiring 5-10 years or longer. Vehicle life, individual loan maturity, and the LP's right to distributions are different. The strongest liquidity case is the contractual opportunity to collect and recycle capital sooner.

Film and TV productions can be underwritten as commercial transactions. Assess the buyer's obligation, the delivery conditions, the eligible tax incentive, the security package, the advance rate, and the collection controls. This is where specialist knowledge earns its place.

The case for MPL stands on its own: private-credit discipline applied to a specialized trade-finance market, with the option to add separately priced upside. Investors do not need a claim of universal outperformance to see the opportunity. They need an attractive, documented path from funding to repayment.

Citations

¹ 2022 Preqin Global Private Debt Report

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³ Pitchbook NVCA Venture Monitor Q3 2023

<https://pitchbook.com/news/reports/q3-2023-pitchbook-nvca-venture-monitor>

⁴ Pitchbook NVCA Venture Monitor Q2 2023

<https://pitchbook.com/news/reports/q2-2023-pitchbook-nvca-venture-monitor>

⁵ Venture Returns Outperform Public Markets Over Many Periods

<https://www.av.vc/blog/venture-returns-outperform-public-markets>

⁶ Global Venture Capital on Track to Hit USD 1TN by 2022

<https://docs.preqin.com/press/Global-VC-Perspectives-Sep-19.pdf>

⁷ Private Credit Strategies: An Introduction (September 2017; retained November 2023 PDF)

<https://www.cambridgeassociates.com/insight/private-credit-strategies-introduction/>

⁸ ACA: Angel Returns Beat All Asset Classes but Pose Greater Risk (May 25, 2023)

<https://angelcapitalassociation.org/blog/angel-returns-beat-classes/>

⁹ Böni & Manigart, Private Debt Fund Returns, Persistence, and Market Conditions (2022), Table 2. Original source image retained in the supplied folder.

<https://doi.org/10.1080/0015198X.2022.2092384>

¹⁰ Cambridge Associates, US PE/VC Benchmark Commentary: First Half 2022 (January 9, 2023), Figure 1 and figure notes.

<https://www.cambridgeassociates.com/en-eu/insight/us-pe-vc-benchmark-commentary-first-half-2022/>

¹¹ Cambridge Associates, Real Estate Index and Selected Benchmark Statistics, December 31, 2021, page 3 (horizon-return table). Supplied file: WEB-2021-Q4-Real-Estate-Benchmark-Book.pdf. One-year return: 25.17%.

¹² SAG-AFTRA, What Is an Interim Agreement? (August 21, 2023).

<https://www.sagaftra.org/what-interim-agreement>

^{12a} SAG-AFTRA, Update on the Interim Agreement (August 14, 2023).

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¹³ Federal Reserve, FOMC statement (July 26, 2023).

<https://www.federalreserve.gov/newsevents/pressreleases/monetary20230726a.htm>

¹⁴ SS&C, Navigating Private Credit: Look Before You Launch, page 2, citing Preqin. Supplied PDF retained with the original research; used to date and distinguish the 2021 fundraising/AUM figures and the historical 2026 forecast.

¹⁵ Federal Reserve, Joint Statement on Completing the LIBOR Transition (April 26, 2023).

<https://www.federalreserve.gov/supervisionreg/srletters/SR2302.htm>

¹⁶ UniFi Completion Guarantors, FAQ: completion-bond scope and limitations (accessed September 2026; structural clarification only).

<https://www.unifibonds.com/faq/>

Contact

If you'd like to learn more about media production lending (MPL) or other opportunities in the space, contact our team at FilmHedge:

Lenders and investors interested in learning more about opportunities in the space can contact: lender@filmhedge.com

TV/Film producers can email: producer@filmhedge.com

If you have a question about the data in this report, want to contribute data to our data science studies, or want to consult our data team, contact: data@filmhedge.com

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Errata and Methodology Addendum

Revised September 2026

The original report put a new financing strategy in front of a wider investment audience—media credit or media production lending. Its central contribution remains valuable: film and TV lending can be analyzed as credit against commercial transactions, rather than treated as a single speculative bet on audience demand. This revision strengthens that case by making the evidence and its limits easier to see.

The main text is largely retained from the late-2023 report.

What is preserved

The chapter sequence, core thesis, branding, photographs, and existing data charts remain. All nine values in the original return comparison are retained; 25.17% and 28.63% are displayed consistently as 25.2% and 28.6%. The private-debt source table, early- and late-stage VC charts, angel dispersion figure, and venture-debt activity charts are retained.

What the evidence now establishes

The argument is stronger when it rests on differences an investor can underwrite: a specified payer, a contractual amount, a delivery condition, a security package, and a shorter expected collection cycle. Those features justify evaluating MPL alongside venture and other private-market strategies.

Reading the MPL figures

The original 22.5% debt benchmark, 28.6% debt-plus-equity benchmark, 15–27.5% pricing range, and 12–15-month loan term are retained as reported observations.

The original “APY” wording is changed to “reported annualized pricing” because no compounding convention or reinvestment assumption is documented. No conversion from quoted pricing to realized return is made.

Errata: Performance and Risk

Private-debt ranking and dispersion

The two ranking tables transcribed direct lending as 8.87%. The reproduced source table says 8.78%; direct lending therefore ranks third and distressed debt (8.37%) fourth.

“Specialty finance” is changed to the source-defined “special situations.” Its 12.62% mean is the highest among the five sampled strategies, not proof that MPL or all specialty finance outperforms other asset classes.

Standard deviation is labeled in percentage points and describes dispersion above and below the mean. The source is Böni and Manigart, Table 2; the sample contains 448 funds, including 57 special-situations funds.^[9]

MPL dispersion and risk-adjusted claims

The original MPL standard deviation of 54.41 is replaced with “Not verified.”

Completion protection and the trade-finance graphic

The revision describes completion and delivery protection subject to the bond’s terms. Buyer nonpayment, collection delays, exclusions, currency exposure, and other credit risks may or may not be covered by a completion bond. UniFi’s explanation expressly separates completion protection from the guarantee that a distributor pays. The diagram keeps its original four-step concept, with corrected labels and a separate treatment of tax-incentive collection.^[16]

Angel IRRs and liquidity

CTAN’s 31.0% and TCA’s 25.2% are annualized IRRs across full-history outcome cohorts (2006–2022 and 1997–2022). They were mistakenly placed in a 15-year-return column and later treated as gains accumulated over 15–20 years.

A separate full-history column fixes the label. Their arithmetic mean remains 28.1%; it is not a combined-portfolio IRR. Eight of 247 TCA outcomes is 3.24%, rounded to 3.2%. The conclusion now emphasizes different cash cycles.^[8]

Loan maturity, fund life, and distributions

A 12–15-month loan maturity does not mean an LP can redeem in 12–15 months. Delays, fund lockups, and reinvestment affect distributions. The original 2–5-year MPL and 5–10-year venture vehicle descriptions are retained as indicative structures, not universal terms.

Errata: Benchmark Dates and Market Scale

The original return chart can be retained—with its real labels

Cambridge's First Half 2022 Figure 1 supports the original 2.7% US VC and 6.7% US private-equity figures for the year ended June 30, 2022. It also supports –23.5% Nasdaq, –25.5% Russell 2000, and –10.9% S&P 500 as the public mPME comparators matched to VC cash flows. They are not ordinary calendar-year 2022 public-index returns. Cambridge's private indexes are net of fees, expenses, and carried interest; mPME is a cash-flow-matched comparison method.^[10]

The –16.8% PitchBook figure is –16.8280% rounded, a rolling one-year IRR to March 31, 2023 (Q3 workbook, "US VC IRR," AQ9; date in B10). The retained real-estate book reports 25.17% for the year ended December 31, 2021, not 2022 or 2023. The MPL values remain company-reported observations with an unreconciled calculation basis. The revised chart titles and table make these differences explicit.^[3, 11]

Why the conclusion changes

The original bar heights need not be discarded, but mixed dates and measurement methods cannot establish a universal winner. Statements that MPL outperforms every asset class, beats real estate on a comparable basis, or exceeds angel returns are replaced with the defensible case for specialist credit and shorter contractual cash cycles. The revised chart remains historical context, not a newly constructed index.

VC AUM and the \$43 billion MPL estimate

The cited Preqin release reports \$856 billion of global VC AUM at December 2018. The original \$850 billion is corrected to \$856 billion and dated in the chart and its embedded data. The \$43 billion MPL working estimate is retained, with its production-finance scope, but cannot be reconciled to individual lenders from the supplied files. Different dates and construction prevent a valid market-share or penetration calculation.^[6]

Coverage arithmetic and private-credit scale

Using 300 reviewed productions and 2,500–3,000 releases gives $300 \div 3,000 = 10\%$ and $300 \div 2,500 = 12\%$, not 10–15%. "More than 300" does not establish an exact share, and the populations differ. The \$1.21 trillion private-credit figure is identified as year-end 2021 AUM; the \$2.69 trillion figure remains the historical forecast for 2026. We avoid presenting fundraising, assets, and annual lending as the same quantity.^[14]

Statements retired where the retained evidence is insufficient

The unidentified "SEC filing" supporting a 6–36% VC range and 15% average; the \$750 billion of annual private-credit financing in 2020; a uniform 8–12% versus 3–5% 2010–2019 return comparison;

and venture-debt forecasts of \$52.2 billion, \$28.6 billion, and nearly \$60 billion are removed. No sufficiently specific source or compatible measurement basis was recoverable from the retained material. Their removal does not reverse the report's thesis. Blanket causal claims about higher VC allocations and higher returns, and claims of five years of continuous VC decline, are also narrowed.

Errata: Reconciled 2023 Venture Data

The retained workbook controls the corrections below

Source: Q3_2023_PitchBook-NVCA_Venture_Monitor_Summary_XLS.xlsx. Deal and fundraising data are as of September 30, 2023; the IRR series is as of March 31, 2023. Estimated counts are additions to recorded counts. Source revisions, classification gaps, and rounding can keep stage subtotals from matching the aggregate exactly.

Deal activity

The original Q3 total of \$36.3 billion and 2,935 deals becomes \$36.7 billion and 2,716 recorded deals, or 3,705 including estimates: "Deal Activity," AT94 = 36.7214; AT95 = 2,716; AT96 = 989. Pre-seed/seed remains \$3.2 billion and 1,214 including estimates: "Pre-seed & Seed Activity," AS89-AS91. Early stage remains \$8.5 billion and 1,341: "Early-Stage Activity," AS43-AS45.

Late stage is corrected from \$13.3 billion and 1,074 deals to \$18.4 billion and 970 including estimates: "Late-Stage Activity," AS40 = 18.3524; AS41 = 799; AS42 = 171. The original chart already shows this rebound. Venture growth adds \$6.6 billion and 175 including estimates ("Venture-Growth Activity," AS40-AS42). Rounded stage values sum to \$36.7 billion; stage counts sum to 3,700 versus the 3,705 aggregate, a five-deal source classification difference that we do not force into a category.

Medians, averages, and percentiles

The seed median is \$3.0 million, not \$5.3 million ("Median Deal Size," M9). The late-stage median pre-money valuation is \$52.2428 million, not \$130.3 million ("Median Pre Value," M11); the decline from \$61.0760 million in L11 is 14.46%, rounded to 14.5%. The two larger figures are 75th-percentile chart labels. Early-stage deal size fell 26.6656% from \$6.625 million to \$4.858406 million (K10 and M10), supporting 26.7%.

Median fund size is \$30.0 million and average size \$132.1 million ("Fundraising Medians and Avg," M8-M9). The original \$164.7 million is the 2022 average (L9). The 73.3% experienced-manager share equals \$31.2853 billion divided by \$42.6793 billion ("Emerging vs Experienced Funds," M8; "Fundraising Activity," M8). The 344 funds and \$42.7 billion aggregate are retained.

Returns, exits, and venture debt

The retained VC series gives -7.9553% for Q3 2022, -18.4493% for Q4 2022, and -16.8280% for Q1 2023 ("US VC IRR," AO9-AQ9). The original "fifth straight quarter of declining returns" is replaced with the dated series, which shows an improvement in Q1. The \$35.8 billion and 284 estimated-inclusive Q3 exits remain; the roughly 50% decline refers to IPO/DeSPAC performance indexes, not exit value.^[3]

The first-half venture-debt totals already in the report imply $(20.07 - 6.34) \div 20.07 = 68.4\%$ lower dollar volume and $(1,513 - 931) \div 1,513 = 38.5\%$ fewer deals. These calculations are sound on the stated inputs. The Q3 equity workbook does not independently reconcile these debt totals, so they

remain attributed to the retained report and charts. Activity contraction is not a measure of realized lender performance.

2023 Context and Editorial Perspective

Independent financing during the strikes

SAG-AFTRA's August 2023 guidance made interim agreements available to vetted independent productions that accepted specified union terms. Its August 14 update excluded WGA-covered productions filming in the United States from new interim agreements. This supports a precise version of the original insight: eligible independent productions could pursue a different financing path.^[12]

The price and timing of capital mattered

On July 26, 2023, the Federal Reserve raised its target range to 5.25-5.50% and noted that tighter credit conditions were likely to weigh on economic activity. In that environment, financing reliability and a visible repayment timetable had practical value. Higher interest rates alone do not prove better MPL returns; borrowers' financing costs and credit stress also matter.^[13]

The strongest interpretation of the original thesis

The 2023 evidence points to a portfolio problem: investors could have substantial committed capital while receiving fewer opportunities to turn holdings into cash. Production credit offers a different mechanism. A properly structured loan can be repaid when a contracted asset is delivered and its receivables are collected. The thesis is an inference from the transaction structure and historical financing environment, not the result of a correlation test.

What would make a future performance study conclusive

A reproducible MPL study would need a fixed sample cutoff, every included loan and outcome, dated advances and receipts, outstanding balances, realized losses and recoveries, fees, expenses, leverage, and a clear treatment of equity participation. It should report investment-level and net LP results separately, use consistent periods, and distinguish expected repayment from actual collections. Those requirements identify the next research step; this revision does not substitute new assumptions for missing records.

Reference convention

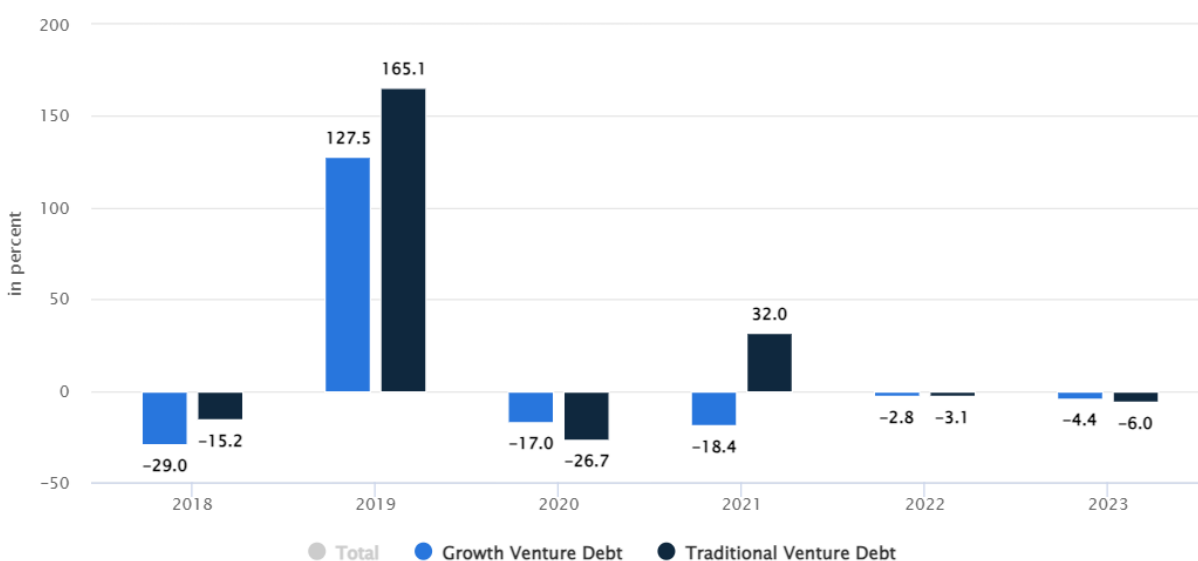
Original references 1-8 remain in the Citations section. References 9-16 below identify added verification sources. The archived Cambridge strategy PDF is the September 2017 text saved in November 2023; the current live page has since changed. No later performance or company data is

used to update the historical argument. The UniFi FAQ is used only to clarify the nature of completion protection, not as a dated 2023 market observation.

Errata: Retained Venture-Debt Illustration

Original graphic preserved for continuity

The original report used the following 2018–2023 illustration twice. Its axis says “in percent” and its legend distinguishes growth venture debt from traditional venture debt, but the retained image does not identify the source, geography, growth measure, or whether the 2023 observation is actual or forecast. The supplied research does not resolve those omissions.



This illustration is retained here as part of the original report’s record. It is not used to establish lender returns, the first-half US contraction, or a long-term decline in venture debt. In the main report, both appearances use the original report’s other venture-debt chart, which explicitly identifies Q2 2023 PitchBook-NVCA data, US geography, and a June 30, 2023 cutoff.

This is a change of evidentiary role, not a finding that every plotted value is wrong. Recovering the underlying export and its definitions would allow the original series to be reassessed. No substitute growth series has been created.

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